

The Cure for Social Media, A New Model

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Date: 10/30/2024

Overview

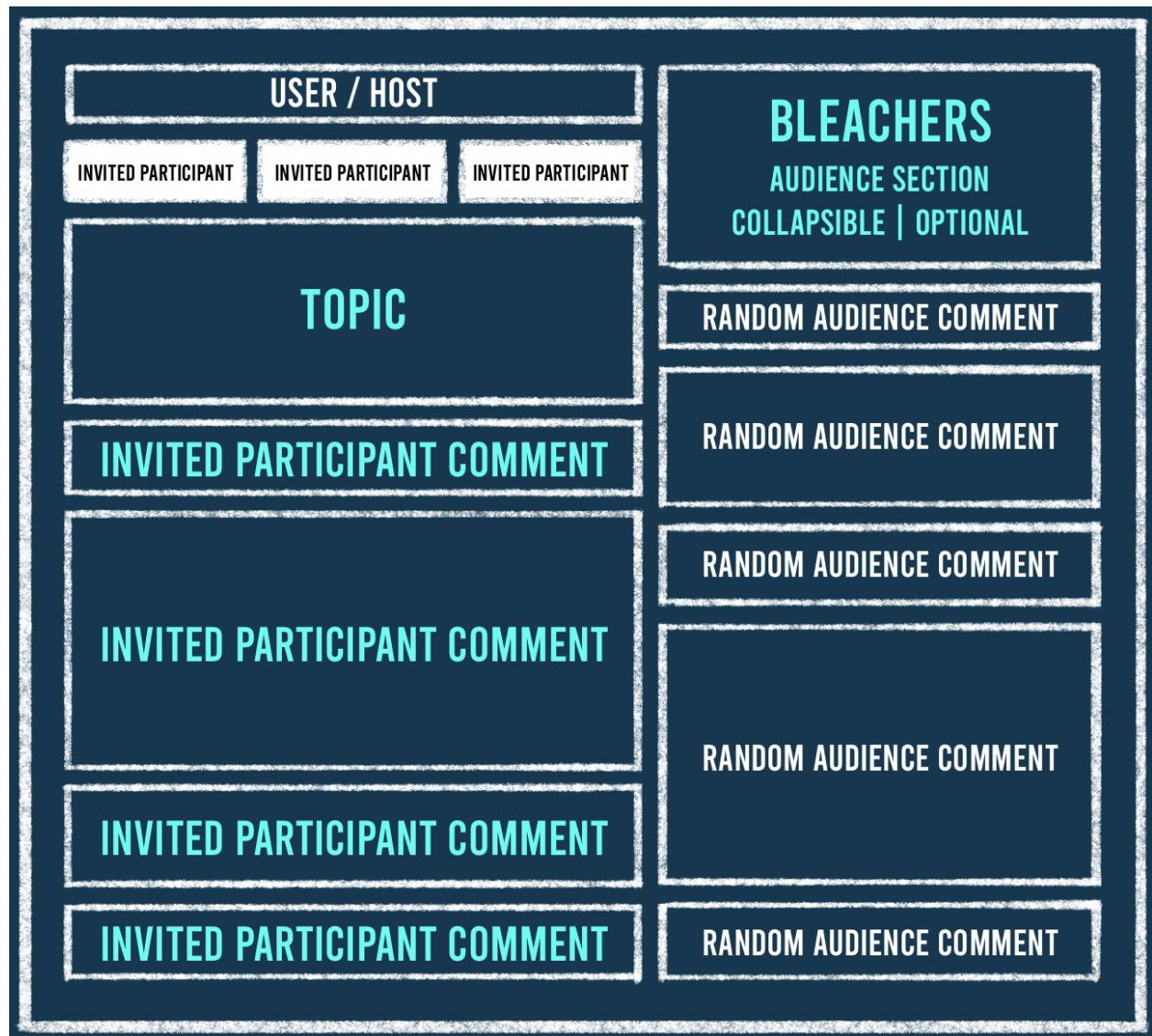
Last week, it occurred to me that the comment model that I've been proposing is actually a really strong foundation for a new kind of social media network, designed with more order and clarity in mind. I know this is a big idea, and I know that the competition is huge. But in the medium term, we don't have to defeat everyone. There are more reasonable goals that will still impress donors. And I am confident that, with the right kind of branding, design, and marketing, we can easily become a big contender.

Social media in general has become a cesspool of uncontrollable bias, with algorithms and structure geared toward maximizing addiction, stifling constructive discussion, and creating an echo chamber. It's time to build a new, better social media platform, which includes better organized conversations, and a thick layer of top-shelf user-generated content, above the chaos, organized and designed into a magazine and news portal for the broader public.

Debate/Bleachers Model for Post Discussions

Comment sections are always the worst, filled with chaos, and generally leading to nowhere constructive. It only takes one undisciplined mind to spoil any hope of a productive discussion.

What we need is an invite-only discussion model, with a “bleachers” section where everyone else can chime in.

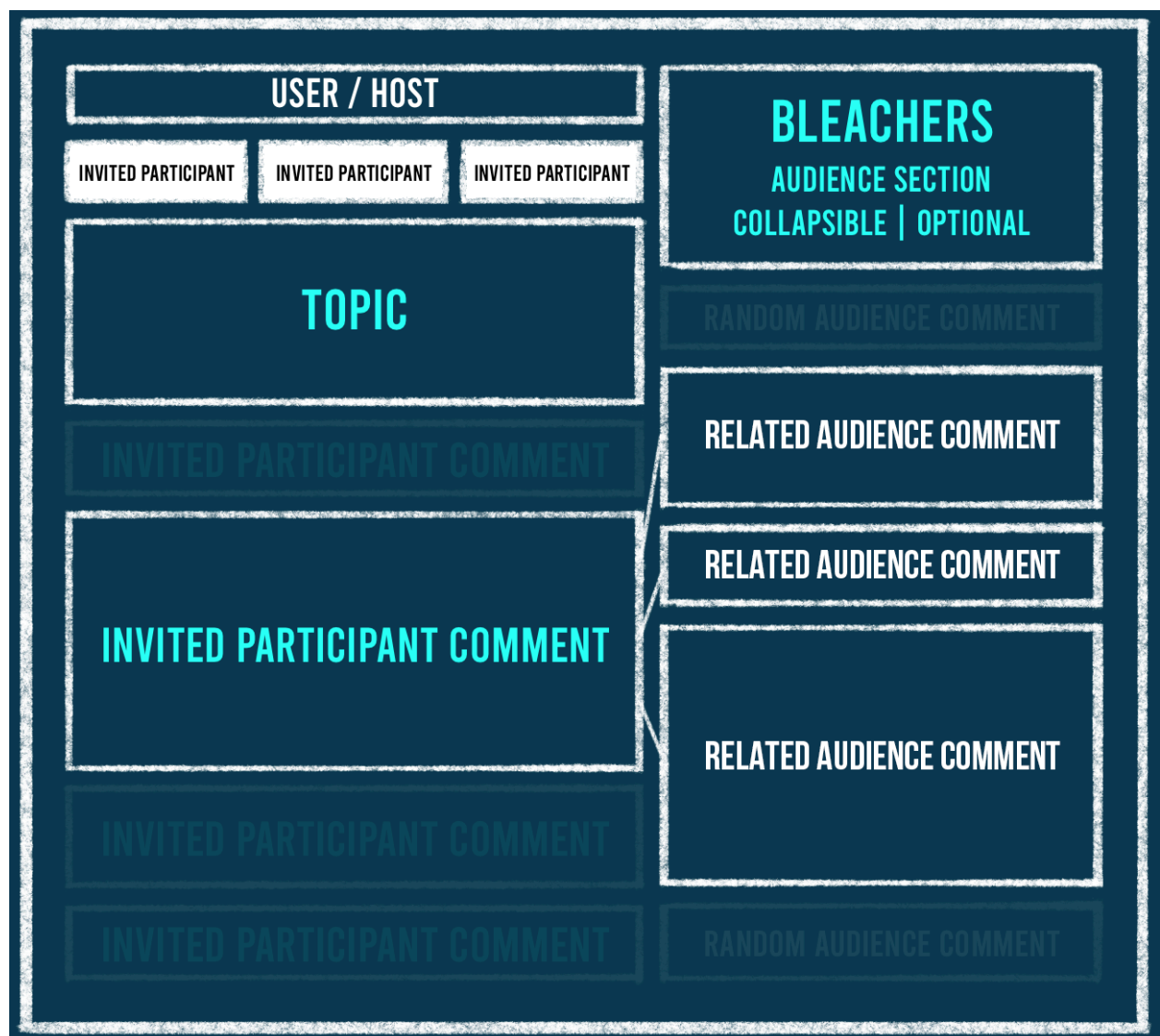


This instantly restructures the comment model from a flood of disorganized noise, into a debate or focussed discussion model, with a stage and an active audience. The author of an article could invite one or more informed and expert minds to engage in an organized, realtime, text-based or multimedia discussion about the established topic (archived and displayed on the

page forever upon completion), while all other guests can go crazy in a more traditional, less organized format, in a collapsible sidebar, or “bleachers” section. This section could also be turned off by the author, if they want even less noise and more focus. The bleachers could also stay open forever, or close when the debate is over.

This separates focus from chaos, the informed from the uninformed.

Guests in the bleachers section can click any response in the debate section, and write their own response directly to it. Clicking a response in the debate section would also collapse or dull unrelated bleacher comments, and only highlight those comments related to the in-focus response. Guests can also be invited into an active discussion by the original post owner. Bleacher comments can be up-voted by guests.



This model represents the American way. Every post is a miniature republic, loosely speaking, organized and curated discussions with an audience comment section, a spotlight on informed participants, and leadership toward a higher goal.

- Posts and invited participant comments can be text-based or multimedia.
- Guests are restricted to text and, once we sort out security concerns, we can allow images.
- Should be invite-only and remain invite-only.
 - Initially for clout, ultimately as one major means of keeping bots out
- Should begin by inviting academics and experts in multiple fields, as well as top comedians and journalists.
 - Hundreds, maybe thousands of initial invitations, to diverse and well-known people with existing reputations
- Public can view, but not contribute to anything
- Members can view all public content, create their own posts, and comment in all bleachers sections of any post.
- Improved algorithms will be focussed more on providing the user with the kind of content that they actually want to see, and less on squeezing every advertising dollar possible.
 - With user monetization, perhaps we can avoid advertising altogether, and create a sustainable and organized free speech platform, untainted by the pressures of advertising revenue.
- We will monetize at some point, but original users of version 1 have a free lifetime account.
- Small, skilled, human teams design graphic presentations around the most popular and curated posts, promote them to our home page, and other news outlets.
- AI helps to curate and moderate, serves as encyclopedia, assistant, or invited contributor.
- Public posts are shareable and embeddable anywhere on the web.

Even when we have billions of users, this social media platform will have an upper layer for the broader public, designed by professionals, and presented as thought-provoking multimedia content.

- This is an engine for building higher thought, interest, education, entertainment, etc.
- It's a news team.
- It's a debate forum.
- It's a peer review platform.
- Even if a few bots make their way into our system
 - Bots should generally never rise above the bleachers section
 - Soured posts can never make it to the upper layer of the site, which is curated by skilled humans.
- The homepage version of a post can be edited by our team for brevity and readability if needed, with a link to the original post.

- We'll build iOS and Android apps with magazine style presentation and UI feel, much more like a book/magazine reader than a website

Some long-term thoughts

- Home page should be custom designed every day, by a small skilled team, with curated posts and custom layout
- Eventually subsections/categories
- One subsection could be something called the "tar pit", or something like that, which has a much more chaotic model, more like disorganized, old-school social media platforms
- We should eventually design a Roku app to serve top-shelf video content, including both a searchable library, and a continuous stream of professionally edited and branded content.
- We could add a channel or two of our own to this platform
 - live commentary by experts or comedians over the top of user-generated content

Proposed timeline for initial MVP is 2 years. Budget outlined in later section.

- 2 years to build the MVP
- 2 years to market and develop further
- We keep going.

This will become the best and most respected social media outlet, with original thought and content on a multitude of topics, generated by a disciplined and professional user base.

Budget for MVP, 2 Year Timeline

Role/Service	Total Annual Cost	Notes
Director & Architect	\$250,000	Joey Livingston
Engineering Team	\$380,000	Estimated maximum Includes • 1 Senior Engineer • 2 Software Engineers
Designer	\$75,000.00	Estimated maximum We need: • Bold ideas • The discipline to design clean interfaces • An understanding of negative space
Product Manager	\$150,000	Estimated max. Should include project management services for now.
QA Team	\$80,000.00	Estimated max
Hosting and other services	\$30,000.00	Estimated max
Additional unknown costs	\$75,000.00	Examples • Fundraising for years 3 & 4 • Conferences • Networking • Flights/hotels
Total Annual Cost	\$1,040,000.00	
2 Year Budget	\$2,080,000.00	

Budget, Next 2 Years

Everything mentioned in first 2 year budget	\$1,040,000.00	
Marketing Manager	\$115,000.00	Estimated max
Marketing Designer	\$75,000.00	Likely an overseas contractor, estimated max
Marketing Budget	\$500,000.00	
Data architecture specialist	\$100,000.00	Likely an overseas contractor, estimated max
Hosting and other services	\$100,000.00	
Total Annual Cost	\$1,830,000.00	
2 Year budget	\$3,660,000.00	